
MANOR OF THE MISSING LORD
A DCC Adventure for 4–6 level 1–2 adventurers

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1 Judge Introduction

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The setting in which this adventure takes place is an ordinary

instance of feudal society. Peasants toil about their daily lives, farming simple crops, raising livestock, and producing basic textiles. Over these peasants presides a lord. Unbeknownst to the players, the lord of the land is in fact dead. His greed and wealth attracted a Treasure Devourer to his manor about a year ago, a magical monstrosity that feeds on treasure. The Treasure Devourer begins its lifecycle as a single microscopic spore, then plants itself like a fungus in a treasury. If noticed early, Treasure Devourers can be taken care of with relative ease. Left unchecked to grow and feed on a vast amount of wealth and treasure, they can grow to immense size and overtake entire rooms, buildings, or settlements in extreme cases. The larger they get, the more powerful their magical energy. This energy attracts other nearby monsters and beings sensitive to a magical presence.

2 Player Introduction (Read Aloud)

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As you all have known for most of your lives, the lord of the land is an arrogant prick who produces nothing useful. He frequently visits his peasantry demanding arbitrary taxes and dues with little rhyme or reason. He is not popular among the peasantry, but this is the way of things. It is easiest to simply grumble "yes, milord," and produce whatever he demands. Sometimes it is coin. Sometimes it is the ripest crops of the harvest or the choicest cuts of meat. Sometimes it is the eldest son for a territory dispute with a neighboring lord. Again, such is the way of things. Refusing to comply is a death sentence at best.

This has been the way of things for as long as anyone nearby can remember. At least, it was -- before this latest harvest. As the leaves of autumn settle beneath the chilling winds of change that foreshadow another harsh winter, it marks the hundredth day of total silence from the lord -- totally unheard of.

Rumors have begun to spread among the commonfolk of the region; what has happened to the lord? Has he fallen victim to some kind of illness? Has he journeyed away to some distant land? And, most importantly, what's stopping one of us from making the trek to his lavish manor and stuffing our pockets with his treasure and riches? As more and more time passes without anyone receiving so much as a collection letter from the lord, this idea becomes more and more tantalizing in the peoples' minds. If he truly is gone or dead, riches await. However, if that isn't the case, he will almost certainly demand the heads of whatever brigands and thieves dared to seek his doorstep looking to rob his grave.

You have decided the risk is now worth the reward. You stand with your allies preparing for the journey ahead.

3 Area Descriptions

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3.1 Area 0: Stable

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#### 3.1.1 Read-aloud

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You enter into a stable that is fairly ordinary, although a bit large for a private residence. Three horse-sized stalls line the walls. Three saddles and other miscellaneous equestrian supplies hang from the walls, and a heavy musk of hay and dirt hangs in the air. One of the three stalls is currently occupied by a brown adult horse.

### 3.1.2 Judge Notes

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- Horse is actually a disguised appendage of the Treasure Devourer waiting to ambush creatures that get too close
- Horse is "breathing" (chest is rising and falling) but air is not passing (Intelligence DC15)
- Horse's tail is sitting still in a pile of hay. The tail is actually a long, veiny appendage that connects to the TD all the way back in the treasury. (Intelligence DC15)
- The horse will make a surprise bite attack on the first player to enter the stall and get close to the horse. d24 + 2 to hit. The Treasure Devourer will then pull the character into the ground and straight to its stomach. If the horse misses, it will continue to make bite attacks until it either: takes 20 damage, has its tail severed by a Mighty Deed, or successfully bites a character and drags them away.
- A bitten character loses consciousness before reaching the stomach of the devourer. If asked whether the taken character is dead, simply state that if the corpse can be located, the character can be turned over.
- If any of the characters have a magical item or particularly valuable piece of treasure on their person, the horse will prioritize that character or specific piece of gear if it makes sense.
- For example, if one player has a magical sword on their belt, the horse will bite the sword instead of the character. Have the PC make a Luck check -- on fail, they are dragged down with the sword. On success, it is ripped from their belt and they are spared.
- If attacked from a distance, the horse immediately retreats.
- Whether it successfully ambushes a character or retreats, be sure to viscerally describe the way the horse's bones break upwards and crunch as it is forced through the small tunnel that was dug by the appendage of the Treasure Devourer.

### 3.1.3 Lootables

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- 100ft rope on the wall
- Three saddles (use book value)

### 3.1.4 XP Rewards

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- If the false horse is discovered before an ambush is triggered and either attacked or avoided, award 3 XP to all players.
- If a player is ambushed by surprise, award survivors 1 XP

## 3.2 Area 0.5: Manor Exterior / Main Entrance

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### 3.2.1 Read-aloud

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Compared to the thatched-roof cottages and small huts that fill the nearby villages and towns, the manor at the top of this hill may as well be a palace. The exterior has been painted white, and the trail on which you stand leads to a large set of engraved double doors at the center of the southern face.

### 3.2.2 Key features

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- Double doors are unlocked and untrapped
- If characters circumnavigate the building, the western wall contains two windows on the second story (15ft up), one of which is halfway open. This window leads to Area 5, the bedroom.

## 3.3 Lobby

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3.3.1 Read-aloud

The double doors reveal a large lobby with a 25 foot ceiling. The floor is black-and-white checkered stone. On the first floor, two closed wooden doors sit along the west wall, and three closed wooden doors sit along the east wall. In the middle of the room, a curved set of symmetrical wooden stairs meet at the first floor, leading to a second floor wooden railing along the northern side of the room.

3.3.2 Key features

- Door C (the middle door on the eastern wall) is a mimic door appendage of the Treasure Devourer. A character who opens the door is surprised by a long, slimy black tongue which coils around the character on a successful d24+4 attack roll. The character may make a DC 17 strength check to resist being pulled down into the barbed fleshy throat. The character loses consciousness after one round in the Treasure Devourer's stomach. Describe the interior of the stomach as moist, cramped, and completely dark. If a character attempts to cut their way out of the stomach, it is as though their blade is striking metal. A character who uses their one turn to create any kind of fire in the Treasure Devourer's stomach will cause it to regurgitate its stomach contents back into the lobby. If this is the first area visited since a character was swallowed in the stable, that character's roll-over check automatically succeeds. In addition to the regurgitated characters, 100 half-melted gold pieces, 5000 half-melted silver pieces, and 25,000 half-melted copper pieces float in a puddle of steaming almost-black golden-hued sludge that drifts from the door into the lobby. The TD retreats its door-mouth back into the Treasury if this happens. If asked whether the taken character is dead, simply state that if the corpse can be located, the character can be turned over.
- A large chandelier worth 100GP hangs from the top of the center of the room.

3.3.3 XP Rewards

- Reward all characters who were not swallowed by the door 1 XP
- If the treasurer devourer is forced to regurgitate, reward all characters 3 XP.

3.3.4 Doors

- A -- To Kitchen
- B -- To Armory
- C -- Mimic Door Trap
- D -- To Armory
- E -- To Dining Room
- F -- To Bedroom
- G -- To Trophy Room

3.4 "Library"/Kitchen+Dining Room

3.4.1 Read-aloud

* 3.4.1.1 Entering from door A (Description of dining room)

Three floor-to-ceiling bookshelves stand flush against one another on the western wall of this room filled with colorful volumes. A long 30 foot dining table surrounded by ten stools sits in the center of the room.

* 3.4.1.2 Entering from door E (Description of kitchen)

Five floor-to-ceiling bookshelves line the walls of this room. The north wall contains an open door.

3.4.2 Key features

- Bookshelves are false and filled with 6 Vampire Book Swarms.
- Vampire Book swarm - Init +2 - Atk bite +5 melee (1d4 + 1) - AC 9 - HD 1d8
- If a player says they "look around" or want to "investigate" the room, ask them which room (north or south).
- There is a trapdoor in the southeastern corner underneath one of the bookshelves which can be discovered with a DC 5 intelligence check by a PC investigating the kitchen. The PCs must move the bookshelf out of the way to access the trapdoor. No check is required to move the bookshelf, but doing so activates all of the Vampire Books if they haven't already been defeated.
- From either room, a DC 12 intelligence check will give the PC a strong feeling that this room is structured like a kitchen and dining room, not a library.
- Dwarves are entitled to a DC 5 check to know that the bookshelves

are not part of the original room.

- Elves are entitled to the DC 5 intelligence check to discover the trapdoor upon entering the kitchen.
- There is a dumb waiter (little elevator for sending food up to the lord's bedroom) in the northern section of the easternmost dining room wall which can be discovered with a DC 5 intelligence check by a PC investigating the dining room. Only a halfling can fit in the dumb waiter to scout out the bedroom.

3.4.3 Doors

- A -- To Lobby
- E -- To Lobby
- G -- Trapdoor To Wine Cellar

3.5 Wine Cellar

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### 3.5.1 Read-aloud

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The trapdoor reveals a dusty staircase that descends into a large basement filled floor-to-ceiling with wine racks.

### 3.5.2 Key features

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- Each PC that descends the stairs must make a Luck check. All characters who fail are bitten by a small spider and must make a DC 10 Fortitude saving throw. on a fail, the PC falls paralyzed after a single dungeon turn and remains paralyzed until  $\geq 1$  HP is restored by any means. On a success, the PC becomes dizzy and sluggish after 1 dungeon turn: -1d on all rolls until  $\geq 1$  HP is restored by any means.
- The giant spider emerges and begins dragging paralyzed party members into a burrow it's dug in the far corner of the room
- Giant Spider - Init +5 - Atk bite +6 melee (1d7) - AC 12 - HD 4d6
- Servants and cooks are hollowed out in silk cocoons in the burrow.
- Exquisite spices worth 50 GP can be found in the apron of the head chef if his cocoon is opened by the players.
- Players can make off with as many bottles of fine wine as they can carry.

### 3.5.3 XP Rewards

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- Award 2 XP for defeating the giant spider and 1 XP for discovering the exquisite spices.

## 3.6 Armory

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3.6.1 Read-aloud

Three full suits of well-constructed plate armor stand upright on display diases along the eastern wall of this long room. The north and south walls are decorated with weapon racks. The western wall contains three doors.

3.6.2 Key features

- three suits of living armor
- Living Armor - Init +0 - Atk bite +6 melee (1d7) - AC 7 - HD 3d6
- two weapon racks
- false door, exactly like the one on the other side in the lobby. If the TD already regurgitated, the appendage has withdrawn and the door simply opens into a slimy dark vertical column.

3.6.3 XP Rewards

Award 1 XP for defeating the living armor.

3.7 Bedroom

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### 3.7.1 Read-aloud

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The stench of ripe sewage immediately assaults you upon opening this door. This is clearly the lord's bedroom. Two windows line the western wall, one on each side of the large bed. A wall-sized mirror sits on the north wall. Two wardrobes line the southern wall. The window on the south side of the bed is open. A chamber pot sits on the floor between the bed and the open window.

### 3.7.2 Key features

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- Bed
- Mirror
- Chamber pot (unemptied)
- Two wardrobes (one is another Treasure Devourer mouth, one contains fine clothes and the key to the treasury)
- Cigars
- Whiskey
- Dumb waiter (little elevator down to kitchen) DC 10 intelligence -- only a halfling can fit

### 3.7.3 XP Rewards

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- Award 1 XP to survivors if the TD takes a victim.

## 3.8 Trophy Room

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3.8.1 Read-aloud

This dusty room contains a chest along the north wall. The east wall holds the heads of two large deer mounted on the wall. An exquisitely-crafted oak table fills the center of the room. On the table is an assortment of small statues, gems, and elaborate decorative knives and shortwords. There is an iron door on the south wall.

3.8.2 Key features

- This is the only iron door. It is locked and can only be opened with the key found in the bedroom or a DC 20 agility check.
- 3 gem-encrusted blades (2 daggers, 1 shortsword) worth twice their normal GP value.
- Behind the northernmost deer head is a hidden scroll containing a random level 1 spell. Elves are entitled to a check to discover the hidden compartment, DC 15.
- Small black tentacles can be seen under the door if investigated.

3.9 Treasury (Treasure Devourer's Lair)

3.9.1 Read-aloud

This L-shaped room extends south and bends to the west. The floor, walls, and ceiling are covered in long, throbbing masses of jet black flesh, akin to a huge network of tree roots originating from the southern side of the room. The flesh roots converge on a hulking, lumpy, pile of flesh covered in hundreds of all-white eyes and misshapen mouths. The creature's mouths open and shut and babble nonsensical noises over one another with no orchestration or rhythm. Teeth clatter together. Occasional tar-like bubbles form and pop, releasing visible steam. Suddenly, you feel a rumbling in the walls of the manor as long, throbbing appendages tear through the house. Small tentacles extend from the bottom of the creature and it begins to crawl toward you as three huge tentacles covered in splinters and dirt are extended toward you. One of the tentacles contains the limp, broken corpse of a horse; another ends in a doorframe, and another ends with a wardrobe. All three contain gaping mouths which chomp at the air as they extend toward you with alarming speed.

3.9.2 Key features

- Treasure Devourer
- Init + 10
- 1d20 action die head
- 3d16 action die tentacles (only while tentacles remain attached)
- Body AC 14 HP 10d8
- Tentacle (x3) AC 10 HP 2d6
- Atk tentacle +2 melee (1d4) range 60ft, enemy grappled on success and pulled toward mouth

- Atk bite +4 melee (1d12) range 5ft
- On a crit, character is swallowed and takes their next turn in the stomach. One turn later they fall unconscious.
- TD is vulnerable to fire (double damage)
- Characters in the stomach who produce flame are regurgitated.
- TD blood is a thick, slimy golden-hued color.

3.9.3 Read-aloud after TD is defeated

The monstrosity's huge mass of flesh gradually begins to cease all movement. Air cavities and bubbles are the last to settle. Soon, all is still in the room except for your breathing and the sound of blood draining from the creature. Slowly, the creature's body deflates as more and more thick golden blood oozes out of it. As the creature deflates, you realize that it was actually obstructing the remaining area of the room. Sinewy, stringy blood vessels and other organic tubes of varying thickness, including man-sized throats linked to the large tentacles extend from the back of the deflated corpse into the back of the room, where another large, bulbous bag of smooth black flesh lies. The outline of several man-shaped objects can be seen inside of the bag of flesh.

3.9.4 Stomach contents

- Swallowed characters
- Characters swallowed less than five dungeon turns ago are alive. All other swallowed characters get rolled over.
- Half-digested corpses of the lord and his two honor guards
- 100 half-melted gold pieces, 5000 half-melted silver pieces, and 25,000 half-melted copper pieces
- any character who digs into the stomach and searches deeper will find 1d4 large pearls made of melted diamonds, rubies, and other rare gems. They are bowling ball sized and smooth like a surface of glass.

4 Conclusion

As you stand with your comrades amid the viscera and treasure, one singular thought begins to creep into your minds: where the hell did this thing come from?